

out checks *every month* to help people pay off their expenses. You can receive up to thousands of dollars a year.

To apply, you must be a U.S. citizen. If you're a non-citizen, you can still be eligible, as long as you are in alignment with the alien eligibility criteria under the 1996 legislation and the amendments that followed it.

All your resources are counted by the SSI, and what you own must not exceed \$2000 for an individual, and \$3000 for a couple. Keep in mind, the SSI is fair when it comes to determining which of your resources to count. It won't count the home that you own or the wedding ring you're wearing on your finger. Your personal items and fancy household appliances will remain off the tally as well. However, it will count any cash, bank accounts, stocks, or bonds that you may have. Also, if you've recently received any type of grant or scholarship, all you have to do is wait nine months to be eligible for SSI. Seems like a pretty fair deal to me. Aside from all that, you must currently be bringing in little to no income to qualify. Call Social Security at 1-800-772-1213 to see if you meet the current income requirements. You can also learn more and apply at www.socialsecurity.gov/ssi/text-understanding-ssi.htm.

Though it does change each year, the monthly benefit rate for an individual is \$623, while couples can receive \$934. There are even some states out there that will take it a step further and actually *add* to the benefits that SSI is already giving! So what you initially receive may increase even more. Not only that, but if you qualify for SSI, you may also qualify for certain services within your state. It just gets better and better, doesn't it? If you need help paying for Medicare, your state may just foot the bill. Maybe you need some assistance with job training? Your state may just take care of all that for you! Contact Social Security for questions.

The Utilities. Paid.

How about getting those utility bills paid? They make it easy in Phoenix, Arizona. There's an organization known as the Arizona Public Service (APS), and they have a program that helps low-income residents to pay their energy bills. That's right – you can get a discount of up to 40% off if you qualify for it! Factoring in how much income your household makes each month, along with how much energy you use,